

Who Shapes Establishment of the digital euro?

Regulation 2023/0212(COD), concerning the establishment of the digital euro, saw 1242 amendments tabled by rapporteurs and shadow rapporteurs, following 438 recorded lobbying meetings with 272 organisations.

The Lobbying Landscape

The legislative process for the digital euro proposal has attracted significant attention from a diverse set of stakeholders. A total of 438 lobbying meetings were recorded, involving 272 different organisations. Among the 30 most active organisations, a ratio of approximately 8.6 commercial entities to every 1 non-commercial entity was observed.

The most active organisations in lobbying for the digital euro proposal were Deutsche Bank AG and Mastercard Europe, both with 19 recorded meetings. EuroCommerce followed with 13 meetings. Both commercial and non-commercial interests engaged on specific policy areas. For instance, Positive Money Europe (a non-commercial entity) focused on governance and oversight, while Mastercard Europe engaged on innovation, competition, and interoperability.

At the European Commission level, “innovation and competition in payments” was the most lobbied theme, with 20 recorded meetings. This was followed by “interoperability and cross-border payments” with 9 meetings, and “cost recovery and funding model” with 6 meetings.

Thematic Overlap and Lobbying Exposure

An analysis of nine MEPs involved in the scrutiny of the digital euro regulation revealed a statistically significant association between an MEP’s overall lobbying exposure (LEI) and the breadth of thematic overlap between their amendments and the themes discussed in their lobbying meetings (Fisher’s exact test, $p=0.0079$). This suggests that MEPs with higher lobbying exposure tend to engage with a broader range of policy themes that are also subject to lobbying activity. The analysis is based on a sample size of $n=9$ MEPs.

Directional Alignment of Amendments

Examining the alignment of MEPs’ amendments with lobbied positions provides insights into the patterns of legislative adjustments. Out of the MEPs with sufficient data for analysis, Nikos Papandreou (S&D Shadow Rapporteur) exhibited a notably high alignment fraction of 0.92, with 23 of 25 evaluated amendment-position pairs moving in the same direction as lobbied positions, and none moving away. Conversely, Pasquale Tridico (The Left Shadow Rapporteur) showed the lowest alignment fraction at 0.08, with 2 of 25 pairs moving toward and 4 moving away from lobbied positions, and a high number of neutral pairs.

Fernando Navarrete Rojas (EPP Rapporteur) had an alignment fraction of 0.447, with 51 of 114 amendment-position pairs moving toward lobbied positions, 26 moving away, and 37 being neutral. Gilles Boyer (Renew Shadow Rapporteur) showed an alignment fraction of 0.521, with 73 of 140 pairs moving toward, 31 moving away, and 36 being neutral. Stephen Nikola Bartulica (ECR Shadow Rapporteur) had an alignment fraction of 0.5, with 5 of 10 pairs moving toward lobbied positions and none moving away. These patterns suggest varying degrees of thematic alignment between MEPs’ legislative proposals and the positions articulated by lobbying organisations during their recorded meetings.

Theme-Level Observations

A comparative analysis of amendment activity and lobbying focus reveals distinct patterns across policy themes. The “role of intermediaries and disintermediation” theme garnered the most amendments, with 372 changes proposed. This theme also saw some lobbying activity, with 3 recorded Commission meetings. In contrast, “offline functionality and accessibility” was a highly amended theme (229 amendments) but recorded no lobbying meetings with the Commission or Parliament. This suggests that parliamentary attention on this aspect may have been driven by other factors than disclosed lobbying.

Conversely, “innovation and competition in payments” was the most lobbied theme with 20 Commission meetings, and it also received substantial parliamentary attention with 182 amendments. “Interoperability and cross-border payments” also attracted significant lobbying (9 Commission meetings) but generated a comparatively lower number of amendments (96), suggesting limited parliamentary uptake of proposed changes on this theme relative to lobbying efforts.

Limitations

This analysis is based solely on publicly disclosed lobbying meetings and amendments, meaning informal contacts and other forms of influence are not captured. Furthermore, while the analysis identifies associations and directional alignment, it does not establish causal relationships between lobbying activity and legislative outcomes.

Produced by an automated pipeline.